

How Reasonable Decisions Create an Unrecognizable Organization

Organizational Drift, Structural Accumulation, and Reality Drift

Reality Drift Framework — Taxonomy Note #3

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The Basic Pattern

Organizations rarely become distorted through one dramatic decision.

They change through a series of local adjustments.

A new team solves one problem.

A new process reduces one risk.

A new metric improves one area.

A new layer coordinates the layers already added.

Each decision appears reasonable.

The resulting organization may not.

The core sequence is:

local adaptation → internal dependency → structural accumulation → coordination loss → organizational drift

What Is Organizational Drift?

Organizational Drift is the gradual transformation of an organization through accumulated decisions that no one intended as a whole.

The organization still functions.

People still perform their roles.

Projects still move.

But the structure becomes increasingly difficult to explain, change, or connect to the original purpose.

The final system is often nobody's design.

It is the residue of many separate solutions.

How the Organization Changes

A problem appears.

A team creates a workaround.

The workaround becomes a process.

The process requires ownership.

Ownership creates a department, tool, meeting, approval, or reporting line.

Other teams adapt around it.

The temporary response becomes infrastructure.

The organization grows by preserving yesterday's solutions.

Why Reasonable Decisions Accumulate

Local decisions are judged locally.

A manager is rewarded for solving a visible problem.

A team is rewarded for reducing its own risk.

A department is rewarded for meeting its own target.

Few people are responsible for the coherence of the whole.

Each unit improves its part.

The organization becomes harder to understand as a system.

Structural Accumulation

Structural accumulation occurs when old decisions remain embedded after the conditions that justified them have changed.

Processes overlap.

Responsibilities blur.

Metrics conflict.

Teams duplicate work.

Coordination becomes a separate layer of work.

The organization begins spending more energy managing its own structure than responding to the outside world.

Organizational Drift and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, Organizational Drift begins when internal dependencies become more powerful than external purpose.

The organization cannot remove a process because too many other processes now rely on it.

It cannot simplify a structure because the structure has become the basis of authority, budget, identity, and control.

The organization remains active.

Its form becomes increasingly detached from what anyone would build from scratch.

Organizational Drift occurs when accumulated adaptations become more authoritative than the conditions they were created to address.

The Core Principle

No one has to choose the final organization.

People only have to keep making locally sensible decisions without revisiting the whole.

The result is a system shaped less by purpose than by path dependence.

Organizational Drift is what happens when yesterday's solutions become today's structure.

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